

Freemasonry: The Craft [C1]

Segretezza, rituali e potere hanno reso quello della massoneria un mondo tanto inquietante quanto intrigante. Abbiamo parlato con un esperto per cercare di scoprirne di più e sfatare alcuni miti.

For centuries, [Freemasonry](#) has been a source of mystery and suspicion and a recurring subject of conspiracy theories. It is often assumed that Freemasons are a secret [cabal](#) of [power-brokering](#) elites who decide the rules of the world. A quick list of some of the famous men who have been Freemasons — and, of course, they can only be men — comprises fourteen presidents of the United States, including George Washington, as well as other prominent [statesmen](#) and politicians, like Silvio Berlusconi, Benjamin Franklin, Simón Bolívar, Giuseppe Garibaldi, and Prince Philip, the Duke of Edinburgh. There are also many writers, composers and artists: Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, Robert Burns, Mozart, Joseph Haydn, Voltaire, Rudyard Kipling, Arthur Conan Doyle, Oscar Wilde, and John Steinbeck. And what organisation other than the Freemasons could have [boasted](#) both Winston Churchill and basketball star Shaquille O'Neal among its ranks, as well as Walt Disney, Harry Houdini, and comedian Oliver Hardy, Henry Ford, Colonel Sanders, the creator of KFC, and Steve Wozniak, co-founder of Apple?

ENLIGHTENMENT

So what is it about [Freemasonry](#) that has proven so attractive to such a diverse range of people? The answer lies in modern [Freemasonry](#)'s origins in 18th-century Britain. While there have been theories about masonic history [stretching back](#) many centuries, and while Scottish [lodges](#) have roots in the 16th century, [Freemasonry](#) as we know it today is a product of [Enlightenment](#) Britain. Specifically, it is a product of a meeting at the [Goose](#) and [Gridiron](#) pub in London, 24 June 1717. There, the four Lodges of Accepted Masons — men involved in the building and [stonemason trade](#) — joined together to become a single Grand Lodge. This was the foundation of modern [Freemasonry](#). The rules, traditions and rituals that were

developed in this Grand Lodge went on to [inform](#) all subsequent [Freemasonry](#) organisations across the world. Notable Freemason members: Benjamin Franklin; Mozart; Oscar Wilde; Colonel Sanders; Shaquille O'Neal; Prince Philip, the Duke of Edinburgh; and Winston Churchill.

THE CRAFT

To find out more about [Freemasonry](#), Speak Up contacted John Dickie, Professor of Italian Studies at University College London. Intrigued by how often he encountered [Freemasonry](#) in his work on Italian history, Dickie wrote The [Craft](#), How the Freemasons Made the Modern World, an exploration of a movement that — with around six million members across the world, 400,000 of them in the UK and over a million in the US — not only helped shape modern society, but still retains substantial contemporary influence. He began by pointing out the central aspect of this organisation: **John Dickie (English accent):** Secrecy is the thing that [galvanises](#) suspicions about the Freemasons and that also creates loyalty among Freemasons. That's the power of the [Freemasonry](#), is that power to generate stories about them [for good and ill](#) by Freemasons and by non-Freemasons. If you're a Freemason, you are the possessor of the secrets of [Freemasonry](#), and that gives you a sense of being a sort of band apart. That cements the collective identity of the Brotherhood, and it also attracts potential members, people who are intrigued by the idea of these great secrets. Culture

Ken Follett: Solstice at Stonehenge L'ultimo libro di Ken Follett, "Circle of Days", ci dà l'occasione di scoprire di più (o almeno provarci) sulla storia e sulla costruzione di Stonehenge, il misterioso cerchio di megaliti risalente al Neolitico. Sarah Presant Collins , Sarah Davison

RITUAL

Much of the attraction of [Freemasonry](#) comes down to secrecy and ritual, the inherent appeal of these two factors and the way they interact. These ceremonies that an initiate goes through before being accepted into The [Craft](#) — the [shorthand name](#) that masons use — have been described as

plays where everyone has a particular part. At the centre of the drama is the long series of encounters the prospective Freemason has with his [peers](#). The [oddity](#) of these rites is obviously part of the attraction, as Dickie explains. **John Dickie:** Not being a Freemason, I can tell you without fear what the secrets are. Secrecy is [locked into Freemasonry](#) and particularly to the rituals that are at the core of [Freemasonry](#). In a number of ways, when you are initiated to become a Freemason, the ritual takes place in secret in this closed, guarded temple. The secrets you learn are hidden behind symbols of various kinds and you have to be able to sort of unlock the symbols. And most of all, you have to [swear an oath](#), a series of [bloodcurdling](#) oaths, in fact, to protect the secrets of [Freemasonry](#). They involve, for example, getting your [throat](#) cut and being buried on the [shore](#) where the [tide washes](#), and that sort of thing. The rituals are exciting, and you have to spend ages memorising them and it gives a real sense of emotional involvement in the way of well-choreographed ritual. Religious rituals are like [farts](#), really. Your own are fine, everybody else's are absolutely weird and horrible, and take a lot of getting used to. And [Freemasonry](#) is the same, their rituals seem [creepy](#) and odd from the outside, but not to those who are more familiar with them.

AIR OF MYSTERY

From the outside, the elaborate [costumes](#), [coded gestures](#) and highly-choreographed ceremonies can seem eccentric. In fact, they mainly [serve the purpose](#) of dressing up secrets that are, in reality, rather universal and [ordinary](#), argues Dickie. **John Dickie:** So what are these secrets that you learn through this very complicated series of ritual procedures, which involves, you know, rolling your trouser legs up and [baring](#) your [breast](#) and being [blindfolded](#)? That thing. Most people have some notion of what these rituals involve. After all this ritual [palaver](#) and all the [fuss](#), what are the secrets of [Freemasonry](#)? And I can exclusively reveal, although these secrets have been well known for almost the entire history of [Freemasonry](#), that there are three great secrets to [Freemasonry](#) that you learn in the course of the three fundamental rituals of [Freemasonry](#) that you have to go through to become a Freemason in the full sense of the term, a

Master Mason. The first secret is that you should try to be a [nice chap](#). The second secret is that you should try to find out a bit more about the world. And the third and most terrible secret that you learn in the course of a ritual that involves being kind of symbolically murdered and then [zipped into](#) this body bag and carried round the Masonic temple and then resuscitated with a sort of magic [hug](#) from another Freemason, is that death is quite a serious business. So the secrets themselves are [toweringly](#) banal, [toweringly ordinary](#), and [that's the whole point](#). The point is that nobody can disagree with them. Whatever religion you are, whatever ethnic background, whatever social background you come from, it's really very hard to object to these things. And that's because [Freemasonry came into being](#) at a time of great religious conflict, a time in which you would be suspected of treason and/or [heresy](#) if you formed something like a secret society with any kind of religious or political or ethical motivation. An Italian Freemason apron made of lambskin, engraved and painted with masonic symbols, such as hammer and compass, 1800.

IN THE US

In the 19th century, [Freemasonry](#) crossed the Atlantic Ocean and established itself in the United States. The years after the Civil War were a fertile time for brotherhoods and fraternal organisations of all kinds, many of which built on [Freemasonry](#)'s structure. They also [borrowed](#) its atmosphere and culture, from the odd rituals to the phony⁴⁵ history. Many had delightfully eccentric names: the Knights of Pythias, the Benevolent and Protective Order of [Elks](#), the Loyal Order of [Moose](#). Yet there was a sinister side as well. There is no connection between the two groups and their [ethos](#) is in direct conflict with that of the Masons, but one of the groups that copied [Freemasonry](#) was, [arguably](#), the Ku Klux Klan. As Dickie explains, however, the basis of [Freemasonry](#) is very human and common. Beneath the solemn oaths, the archaic symbols and the centuries of suspicion, what drove the foundation of the organisation is a set of universally-shared concerns. **John Dickie:** I think it's partly also a fundamental truth about religion. A fundamental truth that the philosopher Bertrand Russell recognised when he said that basically the business of all religions fundamentally is dealing

with the fear of death. Religions are about death. They're about telling you a story that is going to console you or take your mind off the fear of death, that, you know, you're going to get an [afterlife](#). That you needn't be afraid to stare those skeletons in the face, or whatever it might be, because it doesn't end with death. And [Freemasonry](#), too, its rituals are fundamentally about death. If you want to know more about this topic, read the article [Freemasonry: Secret Handshakes And Suspicion](#).

Glossary

- **statesmen** = statisti
- **oddity** = stranezza
- **swear an oath** = prestare giuramento
- **costumes** = vestiti
- **toweringly** = straordinariamente
- **Moose** = alci
- **ethos** = etica, filosofia
- **Goose** = oca
- **shorthand name** = abbreviazione
- **coded gestures** = gesti codificati
- **serve the purpose** = avere lo scopo
- **nice chap** = brav'uomo
- **arguably** = verosimilmente
- **cabal** = cricca
- **Gridiron** = griglia
- **stonemason trade** = mestiere dello scalpello
- **bloodcurdling** = agghiaccianti
- **inform** = influenzare
- **peers** = pari
- **tide** = marea
- **farts** = peti
- **creepy** = inquietanti
- **zipped into** = chiudere dentro con una zip
- **that's the whole point** = è proprio questo il punto
- **boasted** = vantare
- **Enlightenment** = Illuminismo
- **throat** = gola
- **breast** = petto
- **fuss** = trambusto
- **afterlife** = aldilà
- **stretching back** = risalire
- **Craft** = arte, mestiere
- **galvanises** = stimolare

- **shore** = spiaggia
- **ordinary** = comuni, normali
- **baring** = denudare
- **blindfolded** = bendato
- **hug** = abbraccio
- **Freemasonry** = massoneria
- **power-brokering** = mediazione politica
- **locked into** = integrare in
- **washes** = bagnare
- **palaver** = giri di parole
- **came into being** = nascere, prendere forma
- **heresy** = eresia
- **borrowed** = prendere in prestito
- **lodges** = logge
- **for good and ill** = nel bene e nel male
- **Elks** = alci